

THE WINNERS CIRCLE

ANYWAY

The Relentless Power of Doing It Anyway, Any Way You
Can

For everyone with a folder of unfinished things. You know the one.

ANYWAY

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About This Book

There's a folder. Maybe it's literal, maybe it's just the place in your mind where the stalled things live: the project that got as far as a plan, the conversation you keep meaning to have, the work you were going to start once you felt ready. We tell ourselves we're waiting, for the right conditions, more time, more confidence, more certainty it'll go well.

This book is about what's actually happening in that waiting, and why beginning is almost always the answer, and it has a structure that matches its title's two halves.

Part One is Anyway — the courage to act despite the resistance inside you. It's built on one of the most replicated findings in clinical psychology: that action precedes motivation rather than following it. You don't begin because you feel ready; you feel ready because you began. The confidence and momentum you've been waiting for are

byproducts of starting, not prerequisites for it, and the book shows you the mechanism behind that, then how to use it.

Part Two is Any Way — what to do when the resistance isn't inside you but out in the world. When the plan fails, the opportunity vanishes, the door you'd counted on closes for reasons that have nothing to do with you. This is the rarer and more interesting skill: staying in motion toward what you care about when the route you'd chosen disappears. Most books on starting stop at the inner battle. This one gives equal weight to the outer one.

The first thing the book asks is that you act before you've read another page. That instruction is the whole thing in miniature. Everything after it explains why it works and how to keep doing it, drawing on real research, with full citations in the Appendix at the back.

Before You Begin: The Gate

Chapter 1

STOP.

Not yet. Not until you've done the thing.

Here's what I need you to do before you read another word. Take out your phone, open the timer, set it for five minutes. Then think of the thing. You already know which one. It flickered into your mind when you picked up this book, or maybe when you read the title, or maybe it's been sitting at the back of your thoughts for weeks. Quiet and patient and slightly accusing.

The email you haven't sent. The first sentence you haven't written. The call you keep meaning to make. The application you've been "almost ready" to submit for longer than you'd like to admit.

You don't need a plan. You don't need to feel ready. You don't even need to do it well. You just need to do the smallest, scrappiest, most embarrassingly modest version of it, right now, before the voice in your head finishes composing its very reasonable argument for why this isn't the right moment.

Five minutes. Go.

You're back.

Here's what matters: you did something, or you didn't. Either way, you're still reading, and that's already data.

If you did it: notice what's in your chest right now. That flicker of something, not quite pride, not quite relief, something between them, is the whole book.

If you didn't: you're not behind, and this isn't a test you just failed. Notice, if you can, what stopped you. The flavor of that resistance, the specific words it used, the way it made waiting feel like wisdom. That resistance is also the whole book. You've already identified exactly where it needs to meet you. Keep reading. We'll get there together.

Either way, you're exactly where you need to be. Let's get to work.

PART ONE: ANYWAY

The resistance inside you, and how to act despite it.

Chapter 1: The Thing You Just Did

Here's what I want you to understand about the last five minutes.

You didn't just do a thing. You demonstrated something. You proved, to yourself, in a small and unwitnessed way, that the gap between meaning to and doing can be collapsed. That it doesn't require perfect conditions or absolute certainty or the right feeling arriving at the right moment. That sometimes the gap is just five minutes and a decision to stop treating your own life like a waiting room.

That matters more than it might seem right now, and to see why, you have to understand that almost everything you've been taught about motivation is backwards.

Most of us operate, without ever being told to directly, on a sequence that goes like this: first you feel ready, then you feel motivated, then you act. You wait for the green light inside you. You

prepare until the preparation feels complete. You plan until the plan feels solid enough to stand on. The problem is that the green light doesn't reliably come, the preparation never fully completes, and the plan is never quite solid enough, because the future is never quite certain enough, and certainty is a thing that doesn't actually exist and we've all quietly agreed not to mention it. So we wait. And the folder of unfinished things grows.

The sequence is backwards. You don't act because you feel ready. You feel ready because you acted. The motivation comes after, not before. The confidence is a byproduct of beginning, not a prerequisite for it.

This isn't a slogan. It's one of the better-established findings in clinical psychology, and it's worth seeing the mechanism, because the mechanism is what makes it trustworthy rather than just encouraging.

In the 1970s, the clinical psychologist Peter Lewinsohn was working with severely depressed patients and noticed something that ran against the intuition of the time. The patients weren't stuck because they couldn't act. They were stuck because they were waiting to feel like acting, and depression had made that feeling unavailable, possibly for months. Waiting for the motivation to return was a trap, because the motivation was downstream of exactly the activity the patients had stopped doing. The intervention Lewinsohn helped pioneer, now called Behavioral Activation, simply reversed the order. Don't wait to feel like doing the walk, the meal, the small ordinary engagement, do it first, on schedule, regardless of mood, and let the mood follow. It is now one of the most evidence-backed treatments for depression that exists, and its core finding generalizes far beyond the clinic: engagement reliably produces more positive mood than withdrawal does, and it produces it after you engage, not before.

Here's roughly what's happening underneath. When you begin something, even reluctantly, even badly, you activate the brain's reward and goal-pursuit machinery, the circuitry that generates interest, focus, and the specific small satisfaction of progress. That activation shifts your mood a little. The shift makes continuing easier. The continuing produces more activation. The loop that you thought had to start with a feeling actually starts with a movement, and the feeling joins partway through.

This belongs to anyone who's ever been in a rut, faced a blank page, stood at the edge of a hard conversation, or stared at a project that suddenly felt too large and too likely to expose something unflattering about their abilities. Which is all of us, regularly.

The anyway person hasn't solved this. They haven't banished the rut or the blank page. They've just stopped waiting for those things to resolve before they move, because they've learned, through practice and the accumulated evidence of their own history, that the way through is almost never around. It's through.

You're already an anyway person. What you did five minutes ago proves it. The rest of Part One is about doing it more deliberately, more often, and with enough understanding of the machinery that the voice in your head starts to sound less like wisdom and more like what it is: a pattern, a habit of hesitation dressed up as reasonable caution.

Let's learn its moves.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: BEFORE YOU FINISH READING TODAY, DO IT AGAIN. DIFFERENT THING, SAME APPROACH. FIVE MINUTES, SMALLEST VERSION, RIGHT NOW. DON'T WAIT FOR THE END OF THE BOOK. YOU DON'T NEED

ANY MORE INSTRUCTION THAN YOU ALREADY HAVE.

Chapter 2: The Voice That Wanted You to Stop

Let's talk about what happened when you set the timer.

There was a moment, probably very brief, possibly so fast you almost missed it, where a voice said something. Maybe it said this is a gimmick, it won't work. Maybe you'll do it wrong. Maybe now isn't really the right time, you should be more prepared, there's something you need to sort out first. Or maybe it produced a feeling instead of words: a vague reluctance, a heaviness in the chest, a sense that this particular task has a quality of wrongness you can't quite articulate.

That voice. Let's look at it directly.

The first thing to understand is that it isn't you. Or rather, it's a part of you, a learned pattern installed over years of experience, feedback, disappointment, and comparison. It isn't the whole of you,

and it certainly isn't an authority. It has no access to your potential. It has access only to your history, and it is deeply, structurally biased toward caution, because for most of human history caution kept you alive and boldness occasionally got you killed. The voice is old machinery doing an old job in a world that no longer quite matches it.

The second thing to understand is that it has recurring disguises. Once you learn to spot them, they lose most of their power.

The Perfectionist sounds like this: It's not ready yet. Wait until you can do it properly. You don't want to put out something substandard. It presents as standards but functions as a locked door. It rarely specifies what "ready" actually looks like, because if it did, you might achieve it, and then it would have nothing left to say. It keeps the goalposts slightly out of reach by design. And here's what the research knows about it that's genuinely useful: the most paralyzing form of perfectionism isn't about your own standards at all. Psychologists Paul Hewitt and Gordon Flett, who spent decades mapping the structure of perfectionism, found that the most corrosive variety is what they called socially prescribed perfectionism, the belief that other people require you to be flawless and will withdraw their regard if you aren't. You're not trying to satisfy yourself. You're trying to preempt the judgment of an imagined audience that is, in almost every case, far less interested in your failures than you are.

The Forecaster sounds like this: But what if it doesn't work? You haven't thought through what happens if X, Y, or Z goes wrong. You should plan more thoroughly. It presents as prudence but functions as paralysis in sensible clothing. It's exceptionally good at generating downside scenarios and exceptionally bad at acknowledging that waiting has its own costs. It never once models the future in which

you don't begin.

The Comparer sounds like this: Look how far ahead everyone else is. Look how polished their work is, how confident they seem, how long ago they started. It presents as self-awareness but functions as a slow puncture. It selects carefully, showing you other people's peaks, their public successes, their finished things, and setting them beside your private process, your unfinished drafts, your doubts. It is not playing fair.

You can't silence these voices permanently. They're patterns laid down over years, and they'll recur. What the anyway approach does instead is teach you to hear them and move regardless, to recognize each by its signature and note its presence without granting it authority. This isn't suppression. It's closer to learning to identify a particular bird by its call. Once you know it, you stop being startled every time you hear it. You just note: ah, the Perfectionist again. Hello. I'm going anyway.

The practical tool here is what I call the Voice File: a running record, in a notebook or your phone, of the exact words the resistance uses. Not a summary, the actual sentence. "You don't have enough experience yet." "This is the wrong format." "People will think you're trying too hard." Write them down as they come. Within a week or two, patterns emerge, and you'll notice the voice isn't nearly as creative as it seems. It has a handful of moves, repeated in slightly different costumes. Once you can see the costumes, the voice loses the thing it most relies on, which is sounding like the truth.

A map of the voice isn't a cage. It's just information, and information is what the voice has been counting on you not to gather.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: FOR THE NEXT SEVEN DAYS, EVERY TIME YOU CATCH YOURSELF AVOIDING SOMETHING, WRITE DOWN EXACTLY WHAT THE VOICE SAID. DON'T ARGUE WITH IT. DON'T ANALYZE IT YET. JUST RECORD IT. YOU'RE BUILDING THE CASE FILE.

Chapter 3: Scrappy Is the Point

I want to tell you about a song I love that almost didn't exist.

The demo is rough. The vocals slip out of tune in places. You can hear the room, the slight reverb of a small space, the intake of breath before the chorus. By any professional standard it's unfinished. And yet it's alive in a way some more polished recordings of the same song aren't. Something in the imperfection got preserved.

This happens more than we admit. The first sketch that turns out to be the painting. The rough cut the director keeps returning to. The first draft with a quality the later, better-written versions somehow lose. Not because roughness is superior, it isn't, but because the first imperfect version holds onto something careful revision can polish away: the reason you started.

We've been taught that the first version is the embarrassing version, the thing you hide until it's ready. And there are contexts

where that's right, you polish before you publish, you rehearse before you perform. But the belief that the scrappy version is simply inferior, something to get past as fast as possible on the way to the real thing, costs us enormously, because for a great many people the scrappy version never gets made at all. Waiting for readiness keeps them parked at the stage before the beginning, indefinitely.

So here's the reframe: the scrappy version isn't the rough draft of something good. It's the only thing that makes something good possible.

The behavioral scientist BJ Fogg spent years studying how human behavior actually changes, working with thousands of people trying to build new habits, and arrived at a conclusion that sounds almost too simple to be useful: when you make a behavior genuinely tiny, almost embarrassingly tiny, you dramatically raise the odds you'll actually do it, and the doing generates the positive feeling that wires the behavior in. This is the same mechanism Lewinsohn found, viewed from the habit-formation side: the action comes first, the feeling follows, and the feeling is what makes the action repeatable. The target of a beginning isn't quality. Not yet. The target is existence, because existence is the one thing waiting can never produce.

This is what the 1% version is for. Not one percent quality, one percent size. What's the smallest physical motion that counts as a legitimate beginning? Not the plan, the motion.

It isn't "write a business proposal." It's "open a document and write the problem you're trying to solve." It isn't "start a fitness routine." It's "put on the shoes and stand up." It isn't "have the difficult conversation." It's "send a message saying you'd like to talk." It isn't "start the creative project." It's "make one thing today, any size, any quality, just to prove to your hands that they still know how."

The 1% version isn't a concession. It's a strategy, and it works by interrupting a specific loop, the one that runs I should start, but I'm not ready, so I'll prepare more, but the more I prepare the bigger it looms, so I'm even less ready than before. The tiny beginning replaces that loop with a different one: I started. A tiny version exists. Now I can respond to something real rather than to something imagined.

And responding to something real is categorically different from responding to something imagined. You can't revise a blank page. You can't improve a conversation you haven't had. You can't iterate on a product that exists only in your notes. The scrappy first version hands you something to work with, and working with something real is where skill actually develops. It also breaks a particular spell: the spell of the ideal version. The unwritten novel is perfect. The unmade film is perfect. The business you haven't started is flawless in your head, because it hasn't yet met the friction of reality that would expose its weaknesses. As long as you don't begin, the imagined version stays perfect, beautiful, and completely useless. The moment you begin, it becomes real, imperfect, and genuinely workable.

That isn't a consolation prize. It's the whole point.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: NAME THE STALLED THING YOU'VE BEEN WAITING TO FEEL READY FOR. DEFINE ITS 1% VERSION, THE SMALLEST, SCRAPPIEST, MOST EMBARRASSINGLY MODEST PHYSICAL BEGINNING. SET A TIMER FOR TEN MINUTES AND DO IT BEFORE YOU CLOSE THIS BOOK.

Chapter 4: The Discomfort Gym

Courage gets talked about in the wrong register, and the wrong register is getting in your way.

The popular version of courage involves a moment, usually a dramatic one. The leap. The declaration. The point of no return. Courage, in this telling, is a peak experience you either have enough of when the moment arrives or you don't. And this version is almost useless to a normal life, because the moments it describes are rare, and the thing it asks for, a surging override of fear in a high-stakes instant, isn't something you can build by sitting still and hoping it shows up.

The courage that actually changes a life is quieter, more regular, and considerably more boring. It's saying the true thing in a meeting when silence would be easier. Showing someone your work before you think it's ready. Reaching out to a stranger you admire with no

agenda. Starting the hard conversation. Trying the thing you might be bad at, in front of other people, and surviving the experience of being a beginner. This kind of courage isn't a personality trait you either got or didn't. It's a skill, and like every skill it's built through repetition.

There's even some neuroscience to suggest the brain treats it that way. In a 2010 study at the Weizmann Institute, researchers put people who were afraid of snakes into a scanner and asked them to voluntarily bring a live snake closer, choosing to act while still afraid. Acting in the presence of fear, rather than in its absence, engaged a specific region, the subgenual anterior cingulate cortex, that wasn't engaged when people simply gave in to the fear. The finding worth taking from this isn't a tidy story about one brain region, the neuroscience of courage is still young and the precise circuitry is far from settled. It's the more modest and more useful point that courage is an action taken while afraid, not the absence of fear, which means it's something you do rather than something you have, and anything you do, you can practice.

So think of it as a gym, with different equipment for different kinds of risk.

Social courage is speaking the unpopular opinion in a room moving the other way; sending the message to someone you respect, with no ulterior motive, just to say their work mattered; sharing something you made before you think it's ready; finally having the conversation you've been rehearsing in the shower for three weeks.

Creative courage is publishing something imperfect; starting a project in a form you're bad at; showing an early draft to someone whose judgment you trust and actually listening; making something today with the explicit intention that it won't be good, and making it anyway.

And then there's the equipment people most often mistake for courage but which is really its training wheels: plain physical discomfort, chosen on purpose. The cold finish to a shower. The workout you start when you don't feel like it. The walk in bad weather. Be honest about what this is, because the honesty matters. Ending a shower cold isn't courage, there's no social or creative risk in it, nobody is watching, nothing of yours is exposed. It's discomfort tolerance, which is a different and more basic capacity. But it's worth practicing precisely because it's the low-stakes version of the same underlying move: choosing to do the uncomfortable thing on purpose. The body learns, in a setting where failure costs nothing, that discomfort is survivable and ends. That lesson is the raw material courage is built from, the training wheels you ride until the day a real social or creative risk arrives and your nervous system already half-believes you'll come out the other side.

None of these reps has to be large. The point isn't the most impressive thing you can manage; it's the most honest one, the one that genuinely asks something of you. A rep that costs you nothing strengthens nothing.

Rate yourself, right now, in each domain, social, creative, and discomfort tolerance, on a scale of one to ten. Honestly, not aspirationally. Those numbers are your starting weights. You don't begin a new program by lifting the heaviest thing in the room. You begin where you are, add load gradually, and keep showing up. The daily version is simple: one rep from each domain, not all large, not all impressive, but all honest, all real.

What you're building, one rep at a time, isn't fearlessness, which was never on offer. It's a track record. Your own accumulating evidence that you are someone who acts despite fear. And on the

days the voice is loudest, that record is something you can point to: I have done hard things before. I'm doing them regularly. I'm someone who does this. That isn't a small thing to own. It is, quietly, a life-changing one.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: CHOOSE ONE REP FROM EACH DOMAIN, SOCIAL, CREATIVE, DISCOMFORT, AND COMPLETE ALL THREE BEFORE TOMORROW ENDS. START WITH THE ONE THAT FRIGHTENS YOU MOST. THAT'S THE ONE THAT'LL DO THE MOST WORK.

Chapter 5: The Energy Lie

There's one more thing the voice says that deserves its own chapter, because it's the most convincing lie of all: I'll do it when I have more energy.

This one is persuasive precisely because it sounds biological, responsible, like you're taking your body seriously rather than making excuses. And sometimes it's true. Sometimes you genuinely need rest before you can work, and resting is the right and wise choice. We'll spend a whole chapter on that distinction in Part Two, because getting it wrong in the other direction has its own serious cost.

But a great deal of the time, what presents itself as low energy is actually dread. And dread is exhausting in a way that's easy to misread. It sits on your chest, weighs down your concentration, and makes even simple tasks feel laborious, so it produces all the sensations of depletion without the underlying cause. What's actually

draining you in those moments usually isn't a shortage of energy. It's a surplus of anticipation, the energy you're spending imagining how hard the task will be, which is almost always more than the task itself will cost.

Here's the test, and it's the same move you already made at the Gate. If you've been avoiding something for more than a day, you're probably not waiting for energy or motivation. You're waiting for a feeling that won't arrive until you begin. So begin, for five minutes, and watch what happens to the dread. Almost every time, it dissolves on contact with the actual work, because the imagined task and the real task turn out to be different sizes, and the real one is smaller.

Almost every time. Not always. Sometimes the task really is as hard as you feared, and the five minutes are genuinely difficult, and you push through them and they don't transform into anything resembling flow. That happens, and it's worth saying plainly, because a book that promised otherwise would be lying to you. The anyway approach doesn't promise that beginning feels good. It promises that beginning is almost always better than not beginning, which, summed across a life, amounts to nearly the same thing.

What it does ask is that you stop letting the energy lie make the decision for you. The voice would like you to believe that energy is a precondition you must wait to receive. The truth is closer to the reverse: for most ordinary tasks, the energy is on the far side of the starting line, not the near side, and the only way to reach it is to cross.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: FOR THE NEXT WEEK, WHEN YOU CATCH YOURSELF THINKING I'LL DO IT WHEN I HAVE MORE ENERGY, TREAT IT AS A HYPOTHESIS RATHER THAN A FACT. SET THE FIVE-MINUTE TIMER AND TEST IT. KEEP A ONE-LINE LOG: WHAT YOU AVOIDED, WHETHER THE

**DREAD WAS REALLY DEPLETION, WHAT HAPPENED WHEN YOU BEGAN.
THE DATA WILL TELL YOU SOMETHING ABOUT YOURSELF MORE USEFUL
THAN ANY AMOUNT OF SELF-ANALYSIS.**

Chapter 3

PART TWO: ANY WAY

The resistance out in the world, and how to keep moving when the route disappears.

Chapter 6: When the Door Slams

Everything in Part One was about the resistance inside you. But there's a second kind, and the book's title carries it in the gap between one word and two.

Any way.

Because even when you've done all the inner work, acted despite the voice, started the scrappy version, built real momentum, the world will sometimes slam a door in your face. Not because you failed. Not because the voice was right after all. Just because doors slam. Plans fail. Markets shift. People change their minds. Circumstances reorganize themselves with breathtaking indifference to your schedule. And then the question is no longer how do I make myself begin? It's how do I keep moving when the path I'd chosen has vanished?

This is the harder skill, and the rarer one, and it's where most books about starting fall silent. They get you across the first threshold and abandon you at the second.

Here's the distinction that organizes everything in Part Two. When the door you'd planned on closes, the rigid planner asks the wrong question first: how do I get this door open again? Sometimes that's answerable, but often it isn't, and while they're pounding on it, the clock runs. The anyway person asks a different question: what's available to me right now, in the conditions that actually exist, that still moves me toward what I genuinely care about?

Notice the object of that question. It's about what you care about, not about the original plan. And that's the whole hinge of it. A rigid plan is attached to a method, a specific sequence of events that has to unfold a specific way. A durable goal is attached to a direction. When the method fails, a plan attached to method fails with it, totally, because the plan and the method were the same thing. But a goal attached to direction survives the death of any particular route, because the direction was never the route. This is why some people are shattered by a single closed door and others barely break stride: not because the second group is tougher, but because they were holding onto a direction the whole time, and a direction can't be slammed shut.

A woman I'll call Clara spent three years preparing to open a restaurant. She had the location, the investors, the menu, the team. Six weeks before opening, the investors pulled out, a restructuring inside their firm that had nothing to do with her or her restaurant. The door closed completely.

She tried, for a while, to reopen it: chase new investors, rescue the original plan. But she also asked the harder question, what am I

actually attached to here? And the honest answer wasn't the restaurant. It was the feeding of people, the making of an atmosphere, the expression of her cooking. The restaurant had been the method. Those things were the direction. So she pivoted to the method that was actually available: a supper club out of her own home, small, intimate, word of mouth. It had none of a restaurant's infrastructure and all of its soul. Three years later she opened a restaurant after all, a different one, smaller and more personal, because the supper club had built her something no business plan could have, a community of people already devoted to what she made.

The door that slammed turned out to open onto a place she wouldn't have chosen and is grateful she found. That isn't always how it goes, and I won't pretend it is. Sometimes a closed door is simply a loss, and the honest response is to grieve it. We'll come to that. But the any way muscle, the capacity to look around, to ask what else is possible, to find a strange and imperfect route toward the thing that actually matters, is what keeps you in motion when the route you'd counted on is gone.

There's a practice for building it, and it's deliberately small. Call it the Pivot Drill. Take a goal that's currently stalled or blocked and give yourself fifteen minutes to generate three non-obvious, unconventional, possibly slightly strange ways to advance it. Not the right way. Not the sensible way. Three any ways. The only rules: no idea is too small, no route too indirect, and you don't have to use any of them. The point isn't to find the answer in fifteen minutes. The point is to prove to your own brain that alternatives exist.

Because the brain, among its other jobs, is a pattern-matcher with a strong preference for known routes, and when the known route

closes it can genuinely struggle to generate others, not because alternatives don't exist but because it hasn't been asked to look. The Pivot Drill is a deliberate interruption of that default. It tells the brain: look again, differently. And almost always, at least one of the three turns out to be more viable than it had any right to be. More importantly, the act of generating them changes your relationship to the setback itself, from the door is closed, therefore I'm stuck to the door is closed, therefore I need a different door. That shift sounds small. It is the entire difference between someone the world can stop and someone it can't.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: RUN THE PIVOT DRILL ON A GOAL THAT'S CURRENTLY BLOCKED. FIFTEEN MINUTES, THREE ANY-WAY ALTERNATIVES, WRITTEN DOWN. YOU DON'T HAVE TO USE THEM TODAY. YOU JUST HAVE TO KNOW THEY EXIST.

Chapter 7: Grieving the Plan, Keeping the Direction

Before we go further into the art of the pivot, an honest pause, because the previous chapter could be misread as relentless cheerfulness, and relentless cheerfulness is not what the any way life requires.

When a door slams, the first move isn't always to leap for a window. Sometimes the plan you lost was something you genuinely loved, that you'd organized years and identity around, and pretending you can simply pivot past it without feeling the loss is its own kind of avoidance, just dressed in motivational language instead of fearful language. The rigid planner and the relentless pivoter are both, in their way, refusing to be where they are. One won't let go of the dead method. The other won't admit anything has died.

So: when the route disappears, let it be a loss first, if it was one. Name what you're actually grieving, not the restaurant but the version

of your life that had a restaurant in it, the self you were going to become by way of that particular door. That self was real to you even though it never existed, and its non-arrival is a genuine bereavement even though no one else can see the body. Grief that's named tends to move through. Grief that's denied, in the name of being resilient and adaptable, tends to wait, and leak, and reappear later disguised as something harder to treat: a flatness in the pivot, a half-heartedness in the new direction, a quiet resentment of the perfectly good window you climbed through because it wasn't the door.

Here's how the grieving and the pivoting fit together, because they aren't opposites and they aren't even fully sequential. You grieve the method. You keep the direction. The thing you let yourself mourn is the specific route, the restaurant, the relationship as you'd pictured it, the career on the timeline you'd assumed. The thing you refuse to bury alongside it is the direction underneath, the feeding of people, the wanting to love and be known, the work that matters to you. Clara grieved the restaurant for real before she found the supper club, and the supper club was better for it, because she came to it as a genuine new beginning rather than as a consolation prize she resented.

This is the part of the any way life that the language of pivoting and resilience tends to skip, and skipping it is why so many pivots feel hollow. You're allowed to be sad that the door closed. You're allowed to need a little time at the threshold before you start looking for the window. What you're not served by is mistaking the closed door for the end of the direction, or letting the grief for one method become a reason to abandon the thing that method was only ever a way of reaching.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: THINK OF A DOOR THAT CLOSED ON YOU, RECENTLY OR LONG AGO, THAT YOU'VE NEVER QUITE LET YOURSELF GRIEVE. NAME THE METHOD YOU LOST, AND THEN NAME, SEPARATELY, THE DIRECTION UNDERNEATH IT, THE THING YOU ACTUALLY CARED ABOUT, WHICH IS STILL AVAILABLE TO YOU BY SOME OTHER ROUTE. WRITE BOTH DOWN. THE DISTINCTION IS THE BEGINNING OF THE PIVOT.

Chapter 8: The Seven-Day Anyway Experiment

You now have both halves: the inner resistance and the outer one, the courage to begin and the flexibility to continue when the route changes. What you need next is your own data, gathered from your own life, because you are specific in a way no book can be. Your resistance has a texture that isn't quite anyone else's. Your Perfectionist uses particular language. The domains where courage costs you most are particular to your history and to what you were told, explicitly or not, about what you're capable of. The only way to know any of this precisely is to run the experiment and watch what happens.

The Seven-Day Anyway Experiment is one deliberate act of anyway, in a rotating domain, each day for a week. Not for an audience. Not for a record anyone else will see. For the data.

Day 1, Creative. Make something and share it, not when it's ready, today. A piece of writing, a drawing, a photograph, a voice note, a playlist that says something true about your inner life right now. Share it with one person. Not a publishing event, just an act of making-and-showing.

Day 2, Social. Have a conversation you've been avoiding. Not the hardest one, start with the second hardest. Or reach out to someone you admire with nothing to offer but honest appreciation. Or say the thing in the meeting you've been keeping behind your teeth.

Day 3, Discomfort. Do one uncomfortable physical thing on purpose. End the shower cold. Start the workout you've been deferring. Walk farther than is comfortable. Something that reminds your body, and through it your mind, that discomfort is survivable and sometimes even clarifying.

Day 4, Professional. Submit the proposal. Send the pitch. Ask for the feedback you've been afraid to receive. Raise the idea you've kept in your notebook because you weren't sure it was developed enough. Put the work into the world wherever the work belongs.

Day 5, Relational. Tell someone who matters something true, something they deserve to hear that you've been holding back out of awkwardness or uncertainty about how it will land. Not a declaration that demands a response. Just something true. This conversation changed something for me. I've been thinking about what you said for months. I'm proud of you.

Day 6, the Pivot. Take something currently blocked and run the Pivot Drill on it: fifteen minutes, three any-way alternatives, then one small step on the most promising one. This is the day Part Two gets its rep.

Day 7, Rest. Nothing anyway. Deliberately, completely, without guilt. This isn't a freebie or a gap in the experiment, it's part of it, the practice of not performing, not improving, not being brave about anything. Exist for a day. We'll see in the next chapter why this day matters as much as the other six.

Then, at the week's end, sit with it. Where was the resistance heaviest? Where did anyway feel most natural? What surprised you? Which of your three voices, Perfectionist, Forecaster, Comparer, turned out to be loudest? And don't schedule this experiment for some cleaner future week when conditions will be better. There are no better conditions. There's only this week, which will be imperfect, and which is therefore exactly right.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: WRITE TOMORROW'S DATE ON THIS PAGE AS DAY 1, CREATIVE. MAKE SOMETHING MEANT FOR SOMEONE ELSE'S EYES, AND SHOW IT TO THEM BEFORE MIDNIGHT.

Chapter 9: Anyway Without Burning Out

Everything so far has pointed in one direction: begin, act, do it anyway, do it now, do it scared, do it scrappy, find another way when the route closes. All of it is true. And all of it can be twisted into something that will hurt you, which is why this chapter exists.

The twisted version reads the first eight chapters and adds be brave about everything to an already overloaded life. It turns the five-minute start into a mandate for every waking hour. It hears "the energy lie" and concludes that all tiredness is an excuse, that rest is laziness in a convincing costume. That person doesn't become unstoppable. That person burns out, and burnout is not the anyway life. It's another form of not-starting, just with a great deal more suffering on the way down.

The anyway life requires recovery, and not as a grudging concession to human weakness. As an operating principle of any

system meant to run for years rather than weeks.

Here's the distinction the whole chapter turns on, and it's the one I promised back in Part One. There is a difference between pushing through resistance and ignoring genuine depletion, and learning to tell them apart is one of the most important skills in the entire anyway toolkit. Resistance is the natural friction of doing something hard: the reluctance to begin, the low dread, the voice running its familiar arguments, the pull toward something easier. Pushing through it is the courage we've been building, and it's almost always the right move. Depletion is something else entirely, and pushing through it is not courage but slow self-destruction wearing determination as a mask.

The trouble is that the voice will disguise each as the other whenever it suits. It will dress genuine exhaustion as laziness to keep you grinding when you should stop, and dress ordinary avoidance as exhaustion to keep you stopped when you should go. Neither disguise is your friend. So you learn to read the signals directly, beneath what the voice says about them.

Three signals tell you it's depletion, not resistance. The body: persistent fatigue that a good night's sleep doesn't lift, appetite changes, tension that lives in your shoulders or jaw between tasks and not just during them. The work: a mechanical quality where there used to be aliveness, the absence of that small pull-forward of genuine interest, everything feeling like obligation and nothing like discovery. And the people you love: when they start to register as demands rather than sources of replenishment, when you're withdrawing not because you're an introvert restoring yourself, which is healthy and different, but because there's nothing left to give. That last one is the clearest sign the machine needs servicing rather than

driving.

The correction isn't complicated, though it is, for many people, surprisingly hard to permit: deliberate rest. Not the accidental collapse at the end of an unsustainable sprint, but a scheduled, protected, genuinely non-negotiable recovery, a day or an evening or a morning that isn't for productivity or growth or courageous anything. It's for replenishment: sleep, movement, food made with care, time with people who restore you, the kind of reading that asks nothing of you, the walk with no destination. This is why Day 7 of the experiment was a rest day, and why it wasn't optional. The anyway person who lasts isn't the one who pushes hardest. It's the one who's as deliberate about recovery as about action, who treats rest not as what happens after the breakdown but as the practice that prevents it.

Rest isn't the opposite of anyway. Rest is what makes anyway sustainable.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: SCHEDULE A RECOVERY DAY THIS WEEK. NOT A "CATCH-UP" DAY, A RECOVERY DAY. BLOCK IT LIKE YOUR MOST IMPORTANT MEETING, AND WRITE DOWN, IN ADVANCE, THREE THINGS YOU WILL NOT DO THAT DAY.

Chapter 10: Living Anyway, and Any Way

Go back to the thing you wrote at the very beginning, the note in the margin or the scrap of paper from the Gate, the thing you did in those first five minutes, or the flavor of the resistance if you didn't. Read it again, as the person you are now.

Something will have shifted. Not the words, but how they sit, the same moment seen now as part of a longer story. A story about a particular kind of courage, practiced in a particular kind of way, in a world that will not stop manufacturing reasons to wait.

Because that's what the anyway life actually looks like at full length. Not a string of dramatic moments. Not a superhuman willingness to leap into the void with a song in your heart. Just a consistent, practiced, frequently ungainly refusal to let the waiting go on forever, paired with the flexibility to keep moving when the world closes the route you'd planned. The two halves of the title turn out to

be the two halves of a single capacity: anyway, the courage to act against the resistance inside you, and any way, the resourcefulness to act against the resistance outside you. A life needs both. The bravest beginner in the world is still stuck if the first closed door ends them, and the most adaptable pivoter never pivots at all if they can't bring themselves to start.

Both halves scale past the project you've been avoiding to the whole shape of a life. They apply to the relationship you've been meaning to invest in. To the conversation about what you actually want, the one you keep postponing because you're unsure the other person is ready to hear it. To the work you feel called toward but haven't begun because you don't yet know if you're good enough, which is a thing you'll only ever discover by beginning. They apply, in the end, to the question of who you want to be, which isn't a person waiting at the finish of some preparation period but a person assembled, incrementally, out of the acts you choose today: the five scared minutes, the scrappy attempt, the window you climbed through when the door wouldn't open.

And the world isn't going to make this easier. It will keep producing more options, more uncertainty, more sophisticated reasons to defer until conditions improve. The tools will get better at doing things for you, the feeds better at entertaining you while you wait, the voices, inner and outer, better at impersonating wisdom. In that world the anyway habit stops being a productivity tactic and becomes something closer to a way of staying free. The people who move through the coming years with the most agency and meaning won't be the ones with the best information or the most optimized systems. They'll be the ones who practiced, repeatedly and imperfectly, the art of beginning, of continuing, and of finding another way when the first one closed.

I think you're one of them. Not because you're exceptional, though you may be, but because you're here, which means you're already the kind of person who picks the hard thing over the comfortable one, even when the hard thing is just opening a book about acting anyway and setting a timer for five minutes.

So here is the Anyway Pledge. Not a declaration to recite once and frame. A daily instruction, written in the tense that's most useful on a difficult morning. Read it now, then write your own version, in your own words, for your own resistances, in the voice that will actually reach you when the Perfectionist is loud.

I don't need to feel ready. I'll start anyway. I don't need the conditions to be right. I'll find another way. I don't need to know how it ends. I'll begin, and the beginning will tell me.

I will do this badly before I do it well. I will do it scared. I will do it imperfect. I will do it today.

Anyway. And any way I can.

TAKE THIS WITH YOU: EVERYTHING, BUT NOT ALL AT ONCE, BECAUSE ALL AT ONCE IS JUST ANOTHER KIND OF PARALYSIS. TAKE ONE THING THIS WEEK, ANOTHER NEXT WEEK, ANOTHER THE WEEK AFTER, THE FIVE-MINUTE START, THE VOICE FILE, THE 1% VERSION, THE PIVOT DRILL, THE DISCOMFORT GYM, THE EXPERIMENT, THE PLEDGE. THE FOLDER OF UNFINISHED THINGS GETS LIGHTER THIS WAY. SLOWLY AT FIRST, THEN FASTER THAN YOU'D EXPECT.

Go. You know where to start.

The Anyway Toolkit

Four tools, designed to be used immediately and returned to often. The Pledge in Chapter 10 is the creed; this is the reference you come back to when you're deciding what to actually do.

Tool 1: The Voice File

A running record of the resistance, in its own words.

How to use it: Every time you catch yourself avoiding something, write down the actual sentence, not a summary. Within two weeks the patterns are visible, and the voice starts to sound repetitive, which is exactly what it is.

The payoff: You can't argue the voice into silence. You can learn to recognize it. That turns out to be enough.

Tool 2: The 1% Version

The smallest physical motion that counts as a legitimate beginning.

For any stalled thing, finish this sentence: The 1% version of this is ____.

The test: If it still feels daunting, it isn't the 1% version yet. Go smaller. "Write the report" becomes "open the document and type the one sentence I'm most sure of." "Get fit" becomes "put the shoes on." Smaller than feels serious. That's the point, because existence, not quality, is the only target a beginning needs to hit.

Tool 3: The Pivot Canvas

For when a door closes. Four boxes, one page, fifteen minutes.

Box 1 — The direction. Underneath the specific plan, what were you actually trying to reach? (Not "open the restaurant," but "feed people, make an atmosphere, express my cooking.")

Box 2 — The closed door. What happened? What route is no longer available? State it plainly, and let it be a loss if it's a loss.

Box 3 — Three any-way alternatives. Not the right one. Three any ones. Weird is fine. Indirect is fine. Small is fine.

3.

Box 4 — The smallest next step on the most promising one. Not a plan, one physical motion you could make in the next twenty-four hours. (For Clara's supper club: text three friends inviting them to a trial dinner Saturday; buy the ingredients tomorrow.)

Tool 4: The Anyway Pledge, Your Version

Rewrite the template in your own words, for your own resistances, in the voice that will reach you at seven in the morning when the Perfectionist is loud.

I don't need ____ (e.g. to feel ready). I'll ____ (e.g. start) anyway.

I don't need ____ (e.g. the original plan to work). I'll find another way.

I will do this ____ (e.g. badly) before I do it ____ (e.g. well).

I will do it ____ (e.g. scared).

I will do it ____ (e.g. today).

Anyway. And any way I can.

Sign it. Date it. Keep it where you'll see it when you need it.

A Note on the Research

Anyway is built on real science, and this note is an honest account of what that science does and doesn't establish.

The claim that action precedes motivation is not an affirmation; it's one of the more robustly supported findings in clinical psychology. It underlies Behavioral Activation, an approach with roots in the work of Peter Lewinsohn in the 1970s and developed substantially since by researchers including Neil Jacobson, Christopher Martell, and Sona Dimidjian. Behavioral Activation is now considered an empirically supported treatment for depression, with the core mechanism, that engagement produces improved mood rather than waiting for improved mood to enable engagement, well established across many trials.

The claim that tiny beginnings are disproportionately effective draws on the behavior-design research of BJ Fogg, longtime head of

the Behavior Design Lab at Stanford, summarized for general readers in *Tiny Habits* (2019). Fogg's central finding, that radically reducing the size of a behavior raises the probability of performing it and that the performance itself generates the reinforcing emotion, is consistent with the broader habit-formation literature, though the precise numbers attached to it in popular accounts should be treated as illustrative.

The point about courage as action taken while afraid is supported by a 2010 study from the Weizmann Institute of Science, published in *Neuron*, in which voluntarily approaching a feared stimulus engaged the subgenual anterior cingulate cortex. The book deliberately avoids overclaiming here: the existence of a single "courage circuit" that can be trained like a muscle is a simplification, and the neuroscience of fear and voluntary action remains an active area of research. The reliable, useful point is the behavioral one, that courage is something you do in the presence of fear, and that what you do, you can practice.

The account of perfectionism draws on the framework developed by Paul Hewitt and Gordon Flett, whose multidimensional model distinguishes self-oriented, other-oriented, and socially prescribed perfectionism, with the socially prescribed variety most consistently linked to distress and avoidance.

The discussion of witnessing courage in others in the chapters on the Anyway Crew draws on research into moral elevation, associated particularly with Jonathan Haidt, which finds that observing others act virtuously increases prosocial motivation. The book's extension of this to courageous action specifically is a reasonable inference rather than a directly established finding.

Full citations and a fuller discussion are included in the Research Appendix at the back.

About This Book

Anyway is a book about the gap between meaning to and doing, and how to close it, built around the two halves of its own title. Anyway is the courage to act against the resistance inside you, grounded in the well-supported finding that action precedes motivation rather than following it. Any way is the resourcefulness to keep moving when the resistance is external, when the plan fails and the door you'd counted on closes, by holding onto a direction even when a particular method dies. The book gives equal weight to both, names the specific voices that keep you waiting, and offers a small set of tools, the Voice File, the 1% version, the Pivot Canvas, the Pledge, designed to be used rather than admired. The folder of unfinished things is lighter than you think. You just have to open it.

Thank you for reading. Now go do the thing.